The Gender Wage Gap under COVID-19 Economic Shock

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1 Introduction

The COVID-19 pandemic generated one of the largest labor market disruptions in modern U.S. history. Beginning in early 2020, widespread business closures, mobility restrictions, and sector-specific contractions substantially altered employment patterns and wage dynamics. Because men and women are unevenly distributed across industries and occupations, such disruptions may have had unequal consequences across gender.

A large body of research documents persistent gender wage inequality in the United States. Although the gender wage gap has narrowed over time, substantial disparities remain, largely reflecting persistent structural differences in work patterns, occupational sorting, and the unequal distribution of caregiving responsibilities between men and women. Economic shocks can either widen or narrow existing inequalities depending on how they affect labor demand, labor supply, and occupational composition across different groups. The COVID-19 pandemic therefore provides a unique setting to examine how a large, unexpected shock influenced gender wage inequality.

Importantly, the pandemic affected not only wages but also labor force participation. Women experienced disproportionate employment losses during the early stages of the pandemic, partly due to their overrepresentation in service-sector jobs and increased childcare responsibilities associated with school closures. As a result, observed changes in wages may reflect both wage adjustments and selective labor market exit. Distinguishing between these mechanisms is critical for understanding the true evolution of gender inequality.

This paper asks whether the COVID-19 economic shock altered the gender wage gap among U.S. workers. Specifically, I compare wage outcomes between the pre-pandemic period (2018–2019) and the post-pandemic period (2021–2022) using nationally representative data from the American Community Survey (ACS). To isolate wage differences conditional on continued labor market participation, I focus on prime-age, full-time, full-year workers with positive wage income.

Empirically, I estimate log wage regressions in a difference-in-differences framework by interacting a female indicator with a post-pandemic indicator

while controlling for education, age, race, occupation, industry, and state fixed effects. This approach identifies whether women experienced differential wage changes relative to men following the onset of COVID-19.

This paper contributes to the literature in two ways. First, while much of the existing COVID-19 literature focuses on employment losses and labor force participation, this paper examines wage inequality conditional on remaining employed. Second, by implementing a difference-in-differences framework with detailed controls, the analysis isolates whether the pandemic altered the gender wage gap beyond compositional changes in the workforce.

Understanding how the pandemic affected gender wage inequality provides insight into how large structural shocks interact with persistent labor market disparities and informs policies aimed at promoting gender equality.

2 Literature Review and Contribution

A large body of research documents persistent gender wage inequality in the United States. Francine D. Blau and Lawrence M. Kahn (2017) provide a comprehensive overview of the gender wage gap, showing that while the gap has narrowed over time, substantial disparities remain. Differences in education, labor market experience, occupation, and industry explain part of the gap, but a significant portion remains unexplained after accounting for observable characteristics. Claudia Goldin (2014) emphasizes the role of occupational sorting and nonlinear pay structures, arguing that occupations with high returns to long and inflexible hours tend to generate larger gender disparities, particularly during prime working ages associated with family formation.

Traditional human capital models attribute wage differences to variation in education and labor market experience, while Gary Becker (1957) highlights employer discrimination as a potential source of persistent inequality. More recent research emphasizes structural features of labor markets, including occupational segregation, job flexibility, and differential career interruptions, as central mechanisms driving gender wage gaps. These perspectives suggest that gender wage inequality is not solely the result of individual characteristics but is also shaped by institutional and structural constraints.

The COVID-19 pandemic introduced an unprecedented labor market shock, generating widespread employment losses and sectoral disruptions. Several studies document that women experienced disproportionate employment declines during the early stages of the pandemic, particularly in service-sector and in-person occupations (Alon et al., 2020). This phenomenon has been described as a "she-cession," reflecting the gendered nature of employment losses. Other research highlights the role of increased childcare burdens and school closures in reducing female labor force participation during the pandemic period.

However, much of the existing COVID-19 literature focuses primarily on employment and labor force participation rather than wage inequality among those who remained employed. While employment exit is an important dimension of gender inequality, understanding wage dynamics conditional on continued labor

market participation is equally critical. It remains unclear whether pandemic-induced structural shifts—such as changes in industry demand, remote work adoption, and occupational reallocation—widened or narrowed the gender wage gap among workers who stayed employed.

This paper contributes to the literature in two key ways. First, it shifts the focus from employment outcomes to wage inequality conditional on employment, thereby isolating changes in pay from changes in labor force participation. Second, by implementing a difference-in-differences framework with detailed controls for education, occupation, industry, and state fixed effects, the analysis identifies whether the COVID-19 shock altered the gender wage gap beyond compositional changes in the workforce. In doing so, this paper provides new evidence on how large macroeconomic shocks interact with persistent structural inequalities in the labor market.

Recent research also highlights the importance of distinguishing between short-term shocks and long-term structural determinants of inequality. While economic disruptions such as the COVID-19 pandemic may alter employment patterns in the short run, persistent institutional and social factors often continue to shape labor market outcomes over time.

In particular, gender differences in caregiving responsibilities, access to flexible work arrangements, and occupational sorting remain central mechanisms driving wage inequality. These factors are not easily altered by temporary economic shocks and may contribute to the stability of the gender wage gap observed in this analysis.

2.1 COVID-19 and Labor Market Inequality

The COVID-19 pandemic generated an unprecedented shock to labor markets, affecting both employment and wages. Early evidence suggests that the economic impact of the pandemic was uneven across demographic groups, industries, and occupations. In particular, women experienced disproportionate employment losses, a phenomenon often referred to as the "she-cession."

These disparities are closely linked to occupational sorting and differences in job characteristics. Women are more likely to be employed in service-sector occupations that require physical presence, such as hospitality, retail, and caregiving roles. These sectors were heavily affected by lockdowns and social distancing measures.

At the same time, the expansion of remote work created new opportunities for workers in occupations that allow flexible work arrangements. However, access to remote work is uneven and tends to be concentrated among higher-skilled and higher-paid workers. As a result, the pandemic may have amplified existing inequalities across workers with different job characteristics.

Furthermore, the interaction between labor demand shocks and labor supply responses may generate complex patterns in observed wage data. For example, selective exit from employment among lower-wage workers can lead to increases in average wages even when underlying labor market conditions deteriorate.

Taken together, the literature suggests that large economic shocks may not necessarily lead to immediate changes in wage inequality, particularly when structural constraints remain in place. This perspective provides important context for interpreting the empirical findings of this paper.

3 Empirical Strategy and Data

3.1 Data Source

This paper uses individual-level microdata from the American Community Survey (ACS) obtained through IPUMS USA. The ACS is an annual, nationally representative survey conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau that provides detailed information on demographic characteristics, labor market outcomes, income, education, industry, and occupation. The large sample size and consistent annual structure of the ACS make it well suited for analyzing changes in wage inequality over time.

I use ACS 1-year samples from 2018 through 2022. Years 2018–2019 are defined as the pre-pandemic period, while 2021–2022 are defined as the post-pandemic period. The year 2020 is excluded from the main specification due to substantial labor market disruptions and potential measurement concerns during the initial outbreak.

3.2 Sample Restrictions

To examine wage inequality conditional on labor market participation, the sample is restricted to:

- Individuals aged 25–39 (prime-age workers)
- Employed individuals
- Individuals working at least 35 hours per week
- Individuals with positive wage income
- Excluding self-employed workers

The age restriction to 25–39 focuses on prime working years during which gender wage gaps tend to widen, particularly around periods of family formation and childbearing. These restrictions ensure that wage comparisons reflect differences in pay among full-time wage and salary workers, rather than differences in labor force attachment, hours worked, or self-employment income structures.

3.3 Key Variables

Dependent Variable

The dependent variable is the logarithm of hourly wage. Hourly wages are constructed by dividing annual wage income by total annual hours worked. A

logarithmic transformation is used to reduce skewness and to allow coefficients to be interpreted as approximate percentage differences.

Main Independent Variables

- $Female_i$: indicator equal to 1 for women and 0 for men
- $Post_t$: indicator equal to 1 for years 2021–2022 and 0 for 2018–2019
- $Female_i \times Post_t$: interaction term capturing differential post-pandemic effects for women

Control Variables

The regression includes a set of control variables to account for observable differences that may influence wages. Education is included because it affects both occupational choice and earning potential. Race and Hispanic origin are controlled for to capture differences in labor market outcomes across demographic groups.

Industry and occupation fixed effects are included to account for variation in wages across sectors and job types, as earnings differ substantially by industry and occupation. State fixed effects control for geographic differences in labor market conditions and cost of living. Year fixed effects capture aggregate time trends in wages that affect all workers.

By including these controls, the analysis isolates the gender wage gap while holding constant key observable characteristics that are correlated with both gender and wages.

3.4 Empirical Strategy

To examine whether the COVID-19 pandemic altered the gender wage gap, I implement a difference-in-differences framework comparing the pre-pandemic period (2018–2019) and the post-pandemic period (2021–2022). The baseline regression specification is:

$$\ln(wage_{it}) = \alpha + \beta_1 Female_{it} + \beta_2 Post_t + \beta_3 (Female_{it} \times Post_t) + \gamma X_{it} + \epsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

where $\ln(wage_{it})$ is the logarithm of hourly wage for individual i in year t, and X_{it} represents a vector of control variables.

The coefficient on the female indicator (β_1) captures the pre-pandemic gender wage gap conditional on controls. The coefficient on the post indicator (β_2) reflects overall wage changes following the pandemic. The coefficient of primary interest is β_3, which measures whether the gender wage gap changed in the post-pandemic period. A positive value of β_3 indicates that the gap narrowed, while a negative value suggests that it widened.

This specification identifies changes in gender wage inequality under the assumption that, in the absence of the pandemic, wage trends for men and women would have followed parallel paths over time.

The difference-in-differences framework is well suited for this analysis because it allows for the comparison of wage changes across groups exposed to a common macroeconomic shock. By comparing outcomes before and after the pandemic between men and women, the model isolates differential effects that may be attributed to gender-specific labor market dynamics.

A key identifying assumption of this approach is the parallel trends assumption. While this assumption cannot be tested directly, the use of multiple pre-pandemic years and the inclusion of detailed control variables—such as education, industry, occupation, and state fixed effects—help support its plausibility by accounting for observable differences across workers.

Nevertheless, it is important to acknowledge potential limitations of this approach. Unobserved factors, such as firm-level characteristics, job tenure, or differences in work intensity, may still influence wages and are not fully captured in the data. In addition, the pandemic may have affected labor market behavior in ways not fully reflected in wage outcomes alone, particularly through changes in labor force participation.

4 Data Analysis and Results

4.1 Descriptive Statistics

Table 1 presents weighted summary statistics for the primary variables used in the analysis. The sample consists of employed wage and salary workers ages 25–39 who work at least 35 hours per week and report positive wage income. All statistics are calculated using ACS person weights (PERWT) to ensure national representativeness.

The average log hourly wage in the sample is 3.009, corresponding to an average hourly wage of $26.20. The mean age is 31.99 years, and women account for 44.1 percent of the sample. These statistics summarize the overall characteristics of prime-age full-time workers and provide context for the regression analysis that follows.

Table 1: Summary Statistics

Variable	Mean	Std. Error
Log Hourly Wage	3.009	0.0007
Hourly Wage ($)	26.20	0.0217
Age	31.99	0.0042
Education	8.16	0.0023
Female	0.441	0.0005
Observations	1,819,592	

Figure 1 shows that average wages increased for both men and women in the post-pandemic period. However, this pattern should be interpreted with caution, as the sample includes only employed individuals and does not capture workers who exited the labor force during the pandemic.

In particular, lower-wage workers—especially those in in-person service occupations—were more likely to leave employment, while higher-wage workers in occupations that could transition to remote work were more likely to remain employed. As a result, the observed increase in average wages may partly reflect changes in the composition of the labor force rather than true wage growth.

Although the gender wage gap remains visible in both periods, the similarity in the gap before and after the pandemic suggests that the relative wage difference between men and women did not change substantially. However, pandemic-related shocks may have altered the composition of the labor market.

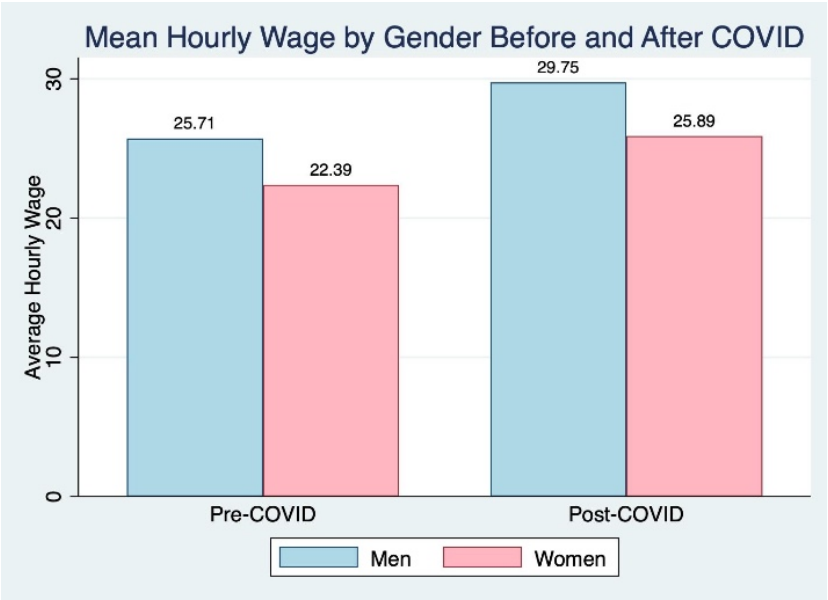

Figure 1: Mean Hourly Wage by Gender Before and After COVID-19

4.2 Raw Gender Wage Gap

To estimate the unconditional gender wage gap, I regress log hourly wages on a female indicator:

$$\ln(wage_{it}) = \alpha + \beta Female_{it} + \epsilon_{it} \tag{2}$$

The coefficient on the female indicator measures the raw wage difference between women and men.

The estimated coefficient on the female indicator is negative and statistically significant, indicating that women earn approximately 18 percent lower hourly wages than men in the raw data. This confirms the presence of a substantial gender wage gap prior to controlling for observable characteristics.

4.3 Conditional Gender Wage Gap

Next, I include controls for age, education, and race to account for observable differences in worker characteristics:

$$\ln(wage_{it}) = \alpha + \beta Female_{it} + \gamma X_{it} + \epsilon_{it} \tag{3}$$

where X_{it} includes age, educational attainment, and race fixed effects.

After including these controls, the female coefficient remains negative and statistically significant, although its magnitude declines slightly. This suggests that differences in observable characteristics explain only part of the gender wage gap, and a substantial portion remains unexplained.

4.4 Pandemic and the Gender Wage Gap

To examine whether the gender wage gap changed following the COVID-19 pandemic, I implement a difference-in-differences specification comparing the pre-pandemic period (2018–2019) to the post-pandemic period (2021–2022):

$$\ln(wage_{it}) = \alpha + \beta_1 Female_{it} + \beta_2 Post_t + \beta_3 (Female_{it} \times Post_t) + \gamma X_{it} + \epsilon_{it} \tag{4}$$

The coefficient on the female indicator reflects the pre-pandemic gender wage gap conditional on controls, while the interaction term captures whether the magnitude of this gap changed in the post-pandemic period.

The estimated female coefficient remains negative and statistically significant, indicating a sizable pre-pandemic wage gap between men and women even after controlling for observable characteristics. In particular, the magnitude of the coefficient suggests that women earn approximately 18–19 percent lower wages than men on average, holding other factors constant. This finding is consistent with a large body of literature documenting persistent gender wage inequality in the United States.

The coefficient on the post indicator is positive and statistically significant, indicating that average wages increased in the post-pandemic period for both men and women. This increase may reflect several factors, including labor market recovery following the initial pandemic shock, inflationary pressures, and shifts in labor demand across industries. In addition, compositional changes in the labor force may contribute to higher observed average wages.

However, the interaction term between *Female* and *Post* is economically close to zero and statistically insignificant. This suggests that, although a gender wage gap persists, its magnitude did not change significantly following the pandemic within this sample of prime-age full-time workers. In other words, while wages increased for both men and women, the relative difference between male and female wages remained largely unchanged.

This result is notable given the substantial disruptions to the labor market during the pandemic. One might expect that differential impacts across industries and occupations—particularly those heavily affected by lockdowns—could

have led to changes in wage inequality. However, the absence of a statistically significant interaction effect suggests that these changes did not translate into measurable differences in the gender wage gap among employed workers.

Taken together, these findings indicate that the COVID-19 shock did not substantially alter conditional wage inequality between men and women. While overall wages increased, the relative position of women compared to men in the wage distribution remained stable.

Table 2: Pandemic and the Gender Wage Gap

	Log Hourly Wage
Female	-0.1887***
	(0.0020)
Post	0.1115***
	(0.0019)
Female × Post	0.0000
	(0.0028)
Age	0.0299***
	(0.0002)
Education	0.1231***
	(0.0004)
Race Fixed Effects	Yes
Observations	152,709
R^2	0.206

Notes: Robust standard errors in parentheses. The dependent variable is log hourly wage. The interaction term measures the change in the gender wage gap after the pandemic. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

4.5 Interpretation and Discussion

The finding that the gender wage gap did not significantly change following the pandemic may reflect several offsetting mechanisms operating in the labor market. On one hand, women experienced greater employment losses and increased caregiving responsibilities during the pandemic, particularly due to school closures and their concentration in service-sector occupations. These factors could have contributed to a widening of wage disparities.

On the other hand, the expansion of remote work and changes in labor demand may have improved labor market opportunities for some women, particularly those in higher-skilled or more flexible occupations. As a result, these opposing forces may have offset one another, leading to little net change in the observed gender wage gap among employed workers.

An important consideration in interpreting these results is selection into employment. Because the analysis focuses only on individuals who remain employed, it does not capture workers who exited the labor force during the pandemic. If lower-wage workers—especially those in in-person service occupa-

tions—were more likely to lose their jobs or leave employment, the remaining sample may consist of relatively higher-wage individuals. This compositional change may help explain the observed increase in average wages for both men and women in the post-pandemic period.

At the same time, higher average wages do not necessarily reflect improvements in individual earnings, but may instead reflect the disproportionate exit of lower-wage workers from the labor market. This distinction is crucial for interpreting aggregate wage trends.

Additionally, the stability of the gender wage gap suggests that the structural factors driving wage inequality—such as occupational sorting, differences in work flexibility, and caregiving responsibilities—remain persistent even in the presence of large economic shocks. The pandemic may have altered the composition of employment, but it does not appear to have fundamentally changed the underlying determinants of gender wage inequality among those who remained employed.

These aggregate results may also mask important heterogeneity across workers. Individuals with higher levels of education or greater access to remote work opportunities may have experienced different wage trajectories compared to those in more vulnerable occupations. As a result, aggregate patterns may conceal distributional differences within the labor market.

Furthermore, the pandemic may have affected longer-term career trajectories in ways that are not immediately reflected in short-term wage outcomes. Interruptions in employment, reduced hours, and changes in job quality may have long-term implications for earnings beyond the period examined in this analysis.

Overall, these findings highlight the importance of distinguishing between wage dynamics and employment dynamics when evaluating the effects of large economic shocks. The observed stability of the gender wage gap should not be interpreted as evidence that the pandemic had no impact on inequality. Rather, it underscores the need to examine multiple dimensions of labor market outcomes to fully understand the effects of economic shocks.

4.6 Heterogeneity and Additional Discussion

The impact of the pandemic may differ across industries and occupations. Workers in service-sector jobs, which often require in-person interaction, were more likely to experience job loss or reduced hours during the pandemic. In contrast, workers in occupations that could transition to remote work were less affected and were more likely to maintain stable employment.

Because women are disproportionately represented in service-sector occupations, these differences may have contributed to unequal labor market impacts across gender. In particular, industries such as hospitality, retail, and personal services were heavily affected by lockdown measures and social distancing policies. These sectors experienced sharp declines in labor demand, increasing the likelihood of employment loss among workers in these occupations.

However, among those who remained employed, the gender wage gap appears stable, suggesting that compositional changes in employment may play an important role in shaping observed wage outcomes. If lower-wage workers were more likely to exit employment, the remaining sample may consist of relatively higher-wage individuals.

In addition, the ability to work remotely may have influenced wage dynamics differently across workers. Occupations that allow remote work are often associated with higher levels of education, greater job flexibility, and higher wages. As a result, workers who remained employed during the pandemic may be positively selected in terms of earnings potential.

More broadly, these patterns can be understood as the result of a large economic shock interacting with existing labor market structures. The COVID-19 pandemic not only reduced labor demand in certain sectors but also accelerated changes in work arrangements, particularly the adoption of remote work. At the same time, institutional responses such as lockdown policies and school closures altered labor supply decisions, especially for workers with caregiving responsibilities.

Taken together, these factors suggest that the observed stability of the gender wage gap may mask underlying changes in labor market composition. While wages among employed workers appear stable across gender, the pandemic may have reshaped the distribution of workers across industries, occupations, and employment status.

These findings highlight the importance of considering both economic shocks and institutional responses when evaluating changes in inequality over time. The persistence of the gender wage gap in this context suggests that structural factors—such as occupational sorting and differences in work flexibility—remain central determinants of wage inequality.

4.7 Wage Trends Over Time

Figure 2 presents average wages over time for men and women across the pre-pandemic (2018–2019) and post-pandemic (2021–2022) periods. Because the year 2020 is excluded from the analysis, the figure does not capture the immediate disruption associated with the onset of COVID-19.

Instead, the figure highlights broader trends before and after the pandemic. Average wages increase for both men and women over time, suggesting that the observed rise in wages may not be driven solely by the exit of lower-wage workers, but also reflects broader upward wage trends.

At the same time, the gap between men and women remains relatively stable. This pattern is consistent with the regression results, which indicate no statistically significant change in the gender wage gap following the pandemic.

The observed increase in wages for both men and women may reflect broader macroeconomic conditions during the post-pandemic recovery period. Following the initial disruption in 2020, labor demand rebounded in many sectors, and tighter labor market conditions may have placed upward pressure on wages.

In addition, inflationary pressures during this period may have contributed to increases in nominal wages.

Importantly, these aggregate trends should be interpreted with caution. Because the analysis conditions on employment, the figure reflects wage outcomes among those who remained employed rather than the full population of workers. If lower-wage individuals were more likely to exit the labor force during the pandemic, the remaining sample may be positively selected in terms of earnings potential.

At the same time, the relatively parallel movement of wages for men and women suggests that these broader economic forces affected both groups in a similar manner. This provides further support for the finding that the gender wage gap remained stable, even as overall wage levels increased.

Taken together, the evidence from Figure 2 reinforces the central result of this paper: although the COVID-19 pandemic substantially affected labor market conditions, it did not lead to a meaningful change in gender wage inequality among employed workers.

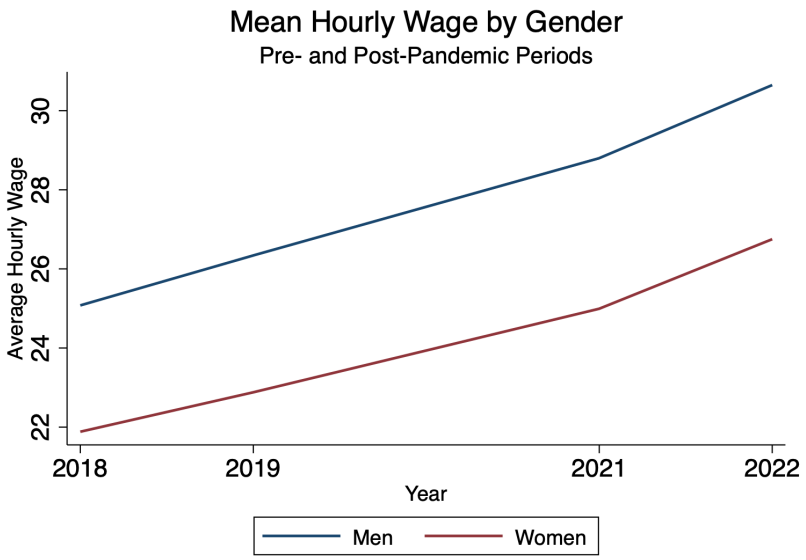

Figure 2: Mean Hourly Wage by Gender, 2018–2022

4.8 Limitations

Several limitations should be considered when interpreting the results. First, the analysis focuses on employed individuals and therefore does not capture changes in labor force participation during the pandemic. As a result, the findings reflect wage inequality conditional on employment rather than overall inequality in the labor market.

Second, the data do not fully capture all relevant job characteristics, such as firm-level factors, job tenure, or differences in work intensity. These unobserved factors may influence wage outcomes and contribute to residual differences between men and women.

Third, the difference-in-differences approach relies on the assumption that wage trends for men and women would have followed parallel paths in the absence of the pandemic. While the use of pre-pandemic data helps support this assumption, it cannot be directly tested.

Finally, the analysis focuses on relatively short-term effects following the pandemic. Longer-term impacts on wages and career trajectories may differ and require further investigation.

4.9 Economic and Policy Implications

The findings of this paper have important implications for understanding how large economic shocks interact with persistent labor market inequalities. While the COVID-19 pandemic generated substantial disruptions in employment and work arrangements, the stability of the gender wage gap among employed workers suggests that underlying structural factors continue to play a dominant role in shaping wage outcomes.

In particular, the persistence of the gender wage gap highlights the importance of occupational sorting, differences in work flexibility, and the unequal distribution of caregiving responsibilities. These factors are deeply embedded in labor market institutions and are unlikely to be substantially altered by short-term economic shocks alone.

At the same time, the results suggest that aggregate wage trends may not fully capture the distributional impact of economic disruptions. Increases in average wages may reflect both compositional changes in the workforce and broader macroeconomic conditions, rather than uniform improvements in individual earnings.

From a policy perspective, these findings underscore the importance of addressing structural sources of inequality. Expanding access to affordable childcare, promoting flexible work arrangements, and reducing occupational segregation may be critical for narrowing gender wage disparities. In addition, policies that support workers in sectors most vulnerable to economic shocks may help mitigate unequal employment losses across gender.

5 Conclusion

This paper examines whether the COVID-19 pandemic altered the gender wage gap among prime-age full-time workers in the United States. Using nationally representative ACS data from 2018 to 2022 and a difference-in-differences framework, the analysis compares wage outcomes before and after the pandemic while controlling for key demographic and labor market characteristics.

The results confirm the presence of a substantial gender wage gap, with women earning significantly lower wages than men even after accounting for observable characteristics such as age, education, and race. At the same time, average wages increased for both men and women in the post-pandemic period.

However, the difference-in-differences estimates indicate that the magnitude of the gender wage gap did not change significantly following the pandemic. In other words, while a persistent gap remains, the relative wage difference between men and women appears to have remained stable among employed workers.

Importantly, these findings should be interpreted with caution. Because the analysis conditions on employment, the results do not capture individuals who exited the labor force during the pandemic. Women experienced disproportionate employment losses in sectors such as hospitality, retail, and other in-person services. As a result, the observed increase in average wages may partly reflect changes in the composition of the labor force, as lower-wage workers were more likely to exit employment.

At the same time, the upward trend in wages for both men and women suggests that broader labor market forces—such as economic recovery, shifts in labor demand, and inflationary pressures—also contributed to wage growth in the post-pandemic period. Therefore, the increase in average wages likely reflects a combination of compositional changes and underlying wage dynamics.

These findings highlight the importance of distinguishing between wage outcomes and employment dynamics when evaluating gender inequality. While the gender wage gap among employed workers remained stable, broader labor market effects of the pandemic may still have had unequal impacts across gender through differences in job loss, labor force participation, and work arrangements.

From a policy perspective, the persistence of the gender wage gap suggests that structural inequalities remain embedded in the labor market. Policies aimed at expanding access to affordable childcare, promoting flexible work arrangements, and reducing occupational segregation may be critical for narrowing gender wage disparities. In addition, targeted support for workers in industries most vulnerable to economic shocks may help reduce unequal employment losses across gender.

More broadly, these findings highlight the complex relationship between short-term economic shocks and long-term structural inequalities. While the COVID-19 pandemic significantly disrupted labor market conditions, its effects on wage inequality appear limited when measured among employed workers. This suggests that underlying structural factors—such as occupational sorting, differences in work flexibility, and the unequal distribution of caregiving responsibilities—continue to play a central role in shaping gender wage disparities.

In this context, large economic shocks may not be sufficient to fundamentally alter existing patterns of inequality, particularly when institutional and social constraints remain in place. Instead, such shocks may primarily affect the composition of employment and the distribution of workers across sectors, rather than the relative wage structure between men and women.

Understanding how these structural forces interact with economic shocks is essential for interpreting observed labor market outcomes and for designing

policies that promote more equitable wage dynamics over time.

Finally, future research could extend this analysis by examining labor force participation decisions, industry-specific dynamics, and the long-term effects of remote work on gender inequality. Incorporating these dimensions would provide a more comprehensive understanding of how large economic shocks affect both wage and employment outcomes across gender.